EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Two Resurrections: Is Rising Again Against Nature?

Given Monday 28 April 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 7:1

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 7 (The Resurrection of the Dead), Introduction and Chapter 1 (the longer version)

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 28 April 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Book So Far

The first shiur after Pesach, on Rosh Chodesh Iyar, opening the spring term. The class began the sefer in January 2024.

Essay	Subject
1	Creation
2	Hashem: how to understand our definition of God
3	Revelation: Torah and prophecy
4	Merits and demerits, mitzvot and aveirot, including free will
5	Teshuvah and the categories of people
6	The *nefesh*: the soul's essence, and what happens when we die

From here to the end of the book: **Essay 7** on *techiyat hametim*, resurrection; **Essay 8** on *ge'ulah*, the Messianic redemption; **Essay 9** on *sechar va'onesh*, not why the righteous suffer (that was Essays 4 and 5) but what reward is and what Olam HaBa is; and **Essay 10**, which is *musar*, "not a philosophical work, it's a practical work" on doing the will of Hashem.

Introductory Point 1: Two Kinds of Resurrection

The very order of the essays, resurrection, then redemption, then Olam HaBa, shows that Saadia understands *techiyat hametim* differently from the Rambam.

The Rambam

For the Rambam, Olam HaBa begins when we die: each person enters it according to his deeds. *Techiyat hametim* is a separate stage: there will be a time when people are resurrected and then die again and go on to Olam HaBa, because for the Rambam Olam HaBa is for the soul alone.

Saadia

For Saadia, as he will develop in Essay 9, **Olam HaBa is body and soul**. So everyone who deserves Olam HaBa will need to have the body resurrected. And there are **two resurrections**:

1. **The main resurrection, which ushers in Olam HaBa.** It is for all of humanity: everyone who deserves it, Jews and non-Jews alike, including the *chassidei umot ha'olam*. It comes at the end of days, after this world ends and a new world begins.
2. **A resurrection when Mashiach comes**, uniquely for the **tzaddikim of Israel**. Those considered righteous over "the last 5,700 years" will be resurrected to enjoy the Messianic era. That era too will come to an end, and they will rise again with everyone else for Olam HaBa, "but they also get this special treat."

The Rabbi gave the terms used for the two: *techiyat hametim be'et hage'ulah*, at the time of the redemption, the Messianic one; and *be'et hayeshu'ah*, at the time of the salvation, which he identified with the final one for all who deserve it.

Why the Messianic resurrection? Saadia describes it later in the essay as a kind of **justice**. The righteous of Israel suffered so much in this world that, aside from their reward in Olam HaBa, they should also see some benefit in **this** world, the one they lived in, before the new world comes.

Because resurrection is such a big subject, he will also discuss the philosophical arguments against it and for it. "In this essay he's talking about resurrection, resurrection both places, but the focus is on resurrection at Messianic time."

Q (Mark): If the righteous are resurrected as a physical benefit for their suffering, what is the real purpose? Can they do more mitzvot and increase their portion?

The same question applies to anyone alive when Mashiach comes, *be'ezrat Hashem* today. In short, which Essay 8 will touch on: **there is still *bechirah***, free will, and active choices to be made. A person's final judgment, the identity he will have for Olam HaBa, will also depend on how he lives in the Messianic era. That applies to the resurrected tzaddikim too: "this extra benefit, this extra choice."

Introductory Point 2: Two Versions of the Essay

This essay, uniquely, exists in two versions. Saadia wrote an essay on resurrection as part of Emunot VeDeot, and then, because the subject mattered so much to people and gave hope amid the suffering of exile, he made it into a **standalone book**. So he goes over things already taught "as if you've never learned it before," where normally he would say "as we learned earlier."

Which version belongs in Emunot VeDeot is an academic debate, but "there's no debate that they were both written by Saadia." The class will follow **the longer one**:

- it contains most of what is in the shorter one, and the Rabbi will supplement whatever is missing;
- **Ibn Tibbon**, who translated the whole book into Hebrew, translated the longer one;
- in the English *Book of Beliefs and Opinions* (the red book), the main text has the shorter essay, and the longer one appears in the **Appendix to Treatise 7** after Essay 10, on page 409.

"You'll notice he's much more verbose in this essay," since it was intended for everyone, including people who had not learned his book.

(The screen share failed again, and the Rabbi posted a Sefaria link for the class to follow: "You'll be pleased to learn I actually got a new computer, *baruch Hashem*.")

Saadia's Introduction

The title

בתחיית המתים, והנכבד שבו מעדי בני ישראל אשר יעד הבורא בהם את ישועה: on the resurrection of the dead, one of the most honoured promises to the Jewish people, which Hashem promised them for the time of the salvation.

"We never had any essay title like that." The shorter edition just says *techiyat hametim*. Again you see the intended audience: "This essay is for every Tom, Dick and Harry, every Jewish person, to give them consolation and hope during the suffering and the exile which we go through."

What the masses believe

Ibn Tibbon writes in the name of the author: blessed be the God of Israel, **המאמין דברו בצדיקו ומקיים אמרתו**, who keeps His promises.

- **The masses of Am Yisrael believe** that Hashem will resurrect our dead at the time of the redemption.
- **They interpret every passage in Tanach about resurrection literally**, and support it with tradition.

That literalism is important, because some were saying there is no resurrection and that all the verses are figurative. Saadia says you cannot do that, and he will develop two lines of defence:

- **Chapter 2:** there are **only four instances** in which the Torah may be interpreted metaphorically.
- **Chapter 4 onward:** he will go through the allegorical interpretations people gave to the resurrection verses and show why even those are wrong. "So clearly this was something which was happening at this time."

A minority of the nation believe in resurrection only at the entrance to Olam HaBa, not at the time of the redemption. Saadia calls that incorrect, "I don't think he calls them heretical," and says they rely on weak proofs. He will prove there are two.

Why he wrote it

It is the duty of every righteous person to explain things properly and to refute what is wrong: **שפתי צדיק ידעון רצון ופי רשעים תהפכות**. Saadia says he took great care with "this book" (he calls it a book, because it was meant to stand alone), so that it would be as clear as possible, and he wrote it for the nation, **להיות להם משען וסעד**, to be a support in their service of God and in bearing the difficulties of exile.

He followed the way Hashem commands for hard times, in **Yeshayahu 35**: **חזקו ידים רפות וברכים כשלות אמצו. אמרו לנמהרי לב חזקו אל תיראו הנה אלהיכם**. Strengthen the weak hands and the failing knees; say to the faint-hearted, be strong, do not fear, here is your God.

Four sources of challenge

Saadia found that all possible challenges to resurrection come from four sources, **ארבעה אין להם חמישי**, "four, with no fifth." These are the four **sources of knowledge** from his introduction to the whole book, which the class learned back in January a year and a half ago. The Rabbi asked the class to recall them:

1. **The senses.** Anything we perceive: "I feel that this seat is under me... I can see the sun, therefore I know there is a sun."
2. **Reason**, common logic: one plus one is two. "That's not sensual. I can't touch that."
3. **Inference**: deriving new knowledge from what we already know.
4. **Tradition**: Scripture and the prophets.

He introduces them "as if we've never seen them before," because this book was written for those who had not learned the main work. In this essay he names them **הטבע והשכל והכתוב והקבלה**: nature, reason, Scripture and tradition. He will refute every challenge from each, and then bring **three major proofs** for resurrection.

Chapter 1: The Challenge from Nature

He begins with nature "because that's inherent. That's the first thing around us."

Question 1: We have never seen it

In nature, animals are born, grow, live and die; we never see them come alive again. Perhaps nature rules out resurrection.

Saadia's answer: this challenge only works for those who believe **the world is eternal**, that nature is nature and always has been and always will be. **But we monotheists believe that the Creator changes the ways of nature whenever He wishes.** All agree that He sent His prophets with signs and wonders. "And even more than that": we believe in **creation from nothing**, which Saadia proved at great length in Essay 1. Philosophically that is very difficult: how can anyone, even God, create something from nothing? "But still, we believe that." And if you believe that, resurrection is easier.

So whoever denies resurrection because "nature doesn't do that" must also deny:

- Moshe's **staff turning into a snake**;
- **the water turning to blood**;

- **the splitting of the Sea**;
- **the sun standing still** for Yehoshua;

and all the other miracles in the books, until he denies **creation from nothing** and ends up denying God. **ותחיית המתים יותר קל**: resurrection is easier and closer to imagine than creation from nothing.

He adds an actual resurrection in Tanach: **the son of the Shunamit**, whom Hashem revived through **Elisha**, the story in the Haftarah of Vayera, where the child cries **ראשי ראשי**, "my head, my head," and dies. The Rabbi noted it is not the strongest proof, because not everyone understands it as a real death; some say the child fainted into unconsciousness and the prophet brought him out of his trance.

"Question one and answer one: Hashem can do it. It's like all the other miracles in Tanach."

Background: God cannot do the impossible

The Rabbi reminded the class of what Saadia established back in the essay on God, accepted by almost every Jewish philosopher: **Hashem cannot do the impossible.** Not because His omnipotence is limited, but because absurdities are not things at all. God cannot make yesterday come back. He cannot make 10 smaller than 5. He cannot make a square into a triangle, "because that's no longer a square, it's a triangle." Can God create a rock He cannot lift? No. "That's not a limitation. That just means He can't do it because it's not possible."

Question 2: There isn't enough matter

So perhaps resurrection is one of those impossibilities. The premise: **matter is finite and recycled.** When a person dies, his body decomposes into the elements, and from those same elements another person is later formed, and then a third and a fourth. If person two was made from person one's matter, how can both be alive at the resurrection? "Hashem can't do that, because Hashem can't do the impossible."

The Rabbi stressed that this is not about reincarnation, which Saadia called nonsense before Pesach, nor about the soul, which was all Essay 6. It is purely about physical matter. A participant (Flora) asked him to go through it again, which he did: if a man died a hundred years after creation, his body decomposed into the atmosphere and the earth, and five hundred years later another was formed from that same material, the resurrection could not bring back both.

Saadia's text: when the body has decomposed and each part has returned to its element, heat, cold, moisture and dryness, and those elements combine into a second body, and the second dies and becomes a third, and the third a fourth, how will each of them be resurrected?

The answer. If a second body could only be formed from the matter of the first, the challenge would be right. But **the elements are far, far greater in quantity than all the bodies formed from them**. "And how much more? Listen to this." The wise know that the air between the earth and the beginning of the first heaven is equal to the whole earth, including its mountains, seas, plants, animals and everything in it, **1,089 times over**, because it is 33 times 33.

"I'm not going to pretend I understand and know about this." What the Rabbi had read is that Saadia takes this from the **Islamic mathematicians and astronomers of the 8th and 9th**

centuries, who measured a degree of the earth's meridian. Whatever the science, the point is that Hashem has plenty of matter. When He creates person two and person three, He does not take person one's matter. Person one's matter stays, dispersed in the earth, the air and the moisture, but it does not enter person two. "Because if it did enter person two, you couldn't do resurrection."

The shorter edition's example. A man with only one cup who breaks it can do nothing until he remoulds it. But a man with many cups can put the broken one aside and remould it later, whenever he chooses. So too Hashem.

An aside on gilgul. For those who do believe in reincarnation, a major question is what happens at the resurrection, "because it's one soul, one identity, and it's got two bodies." That, the Rabbi noted, is a different question from Saadia's, which is about the same matter being used twice. "Okay, let's leave that."

Question 3: Bodies that pass through many forms

In closing, the Rabbi summarised a third question from the chapter: what of a person whose body passes through many different forms? Saadia's answer: **no creature has the ability to destroy something completely**. The matter is always there, and so it will come back and be resurrected.

Summary

1. **Saadia's map:** resurrection (7), redemption (8), Olam HaBa and reward (9), ethics (10).
2. **Two resurrections**, unlike the Rambam: one at the Messianic redemption for the tzaddikim of Israel, as justice for their suffering in this world; and one ushering in Olam HaBa for all who deserve it, Jews and non-Jews. Free will continues in the Messianic era.
3. **Two versions** of the essay; the class follows the longer, translated by Ibn Tibbon, written as a book of hope for the masses in exile.
4. **The masses believe and read literally**; a minority accept only the final resurrection. Saadia will show both exist.
5. **Four possible challenges**, from the four sources of knowledge: nature, reason, Scripture and tradition.
6. **Nature:** if God made the world from nothing and did the miracles of Tanach, He can raise the dead. "Resurrection is easier."
7. **Not enough matter?** God cannot do the impossible, but this is not impossible: the elements are 1,089 times the earth, and Hashem never needs to reuse one person's matter for another, like a man with many cups.
8. **Nothing is ever destroyed completely**, so every body can be restored.

Coming Up

Next week, at the normal time of 6 to 7: **Chapter 2**, the challenges from **reason**, and the crucial question of **when the Torah may be interpreted non-literally**, against those who made resurrection a metaphor. "And hopefully by then I'll be able to share the screen with you all." *Chodesh tov.*

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/2xCmJd1myp4 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com